

Language change: historical and recent changes in the English lexicon

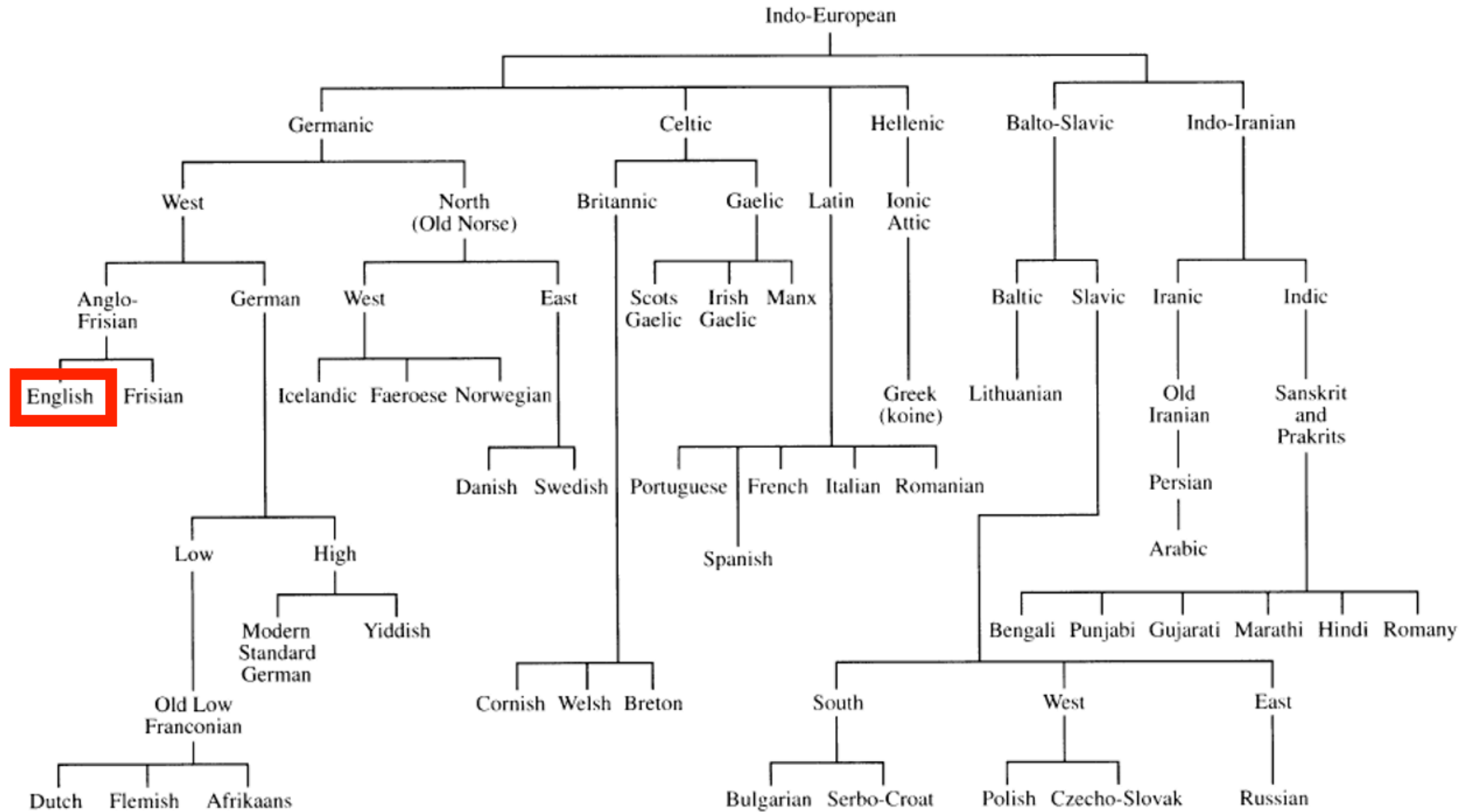
Lexicology and Lexicography – **Course Website**

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The history of the English vocabulary

The Indo-European language family



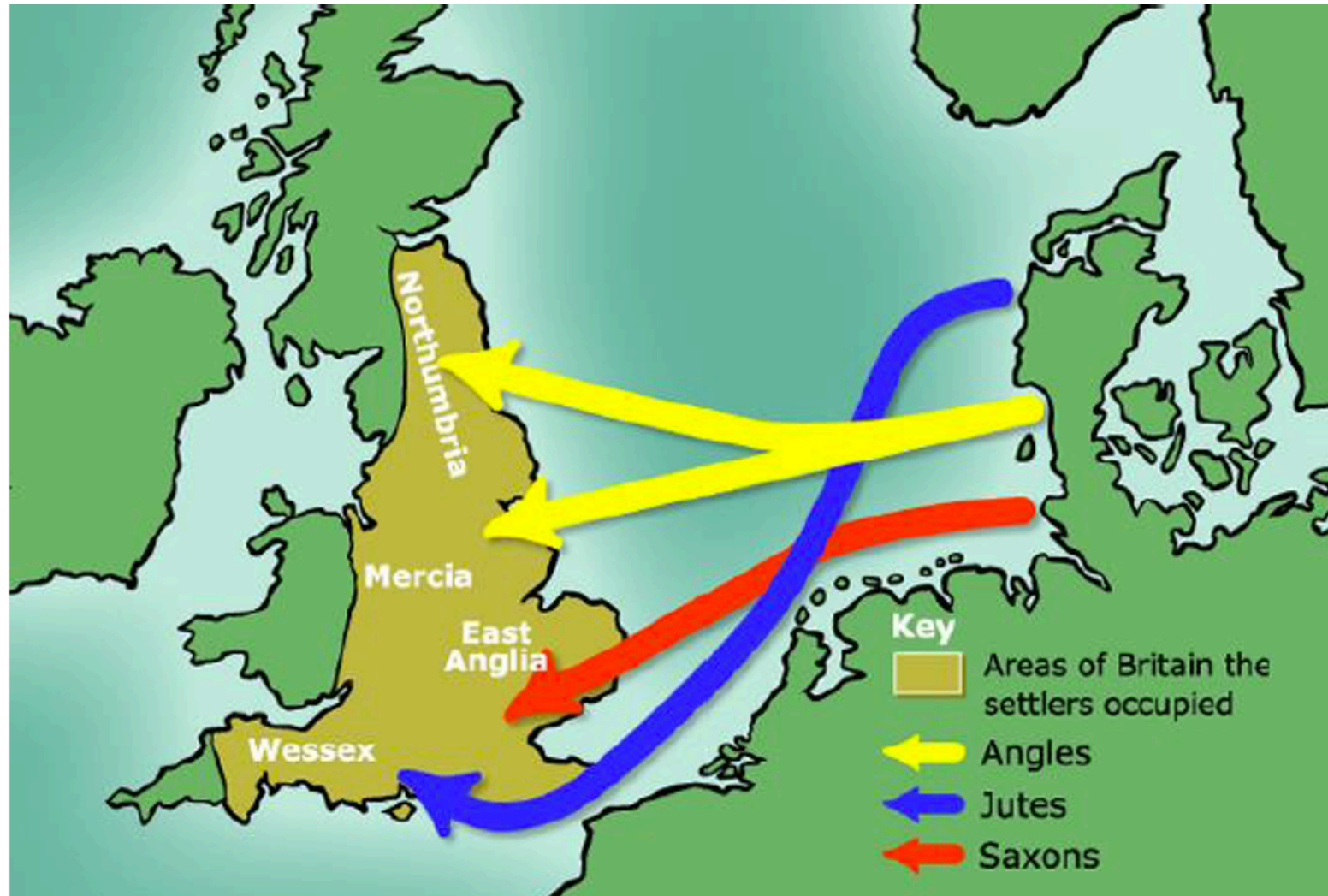
English as part of the Indo-European family tree

Old English (ca. 450–1100)

External history

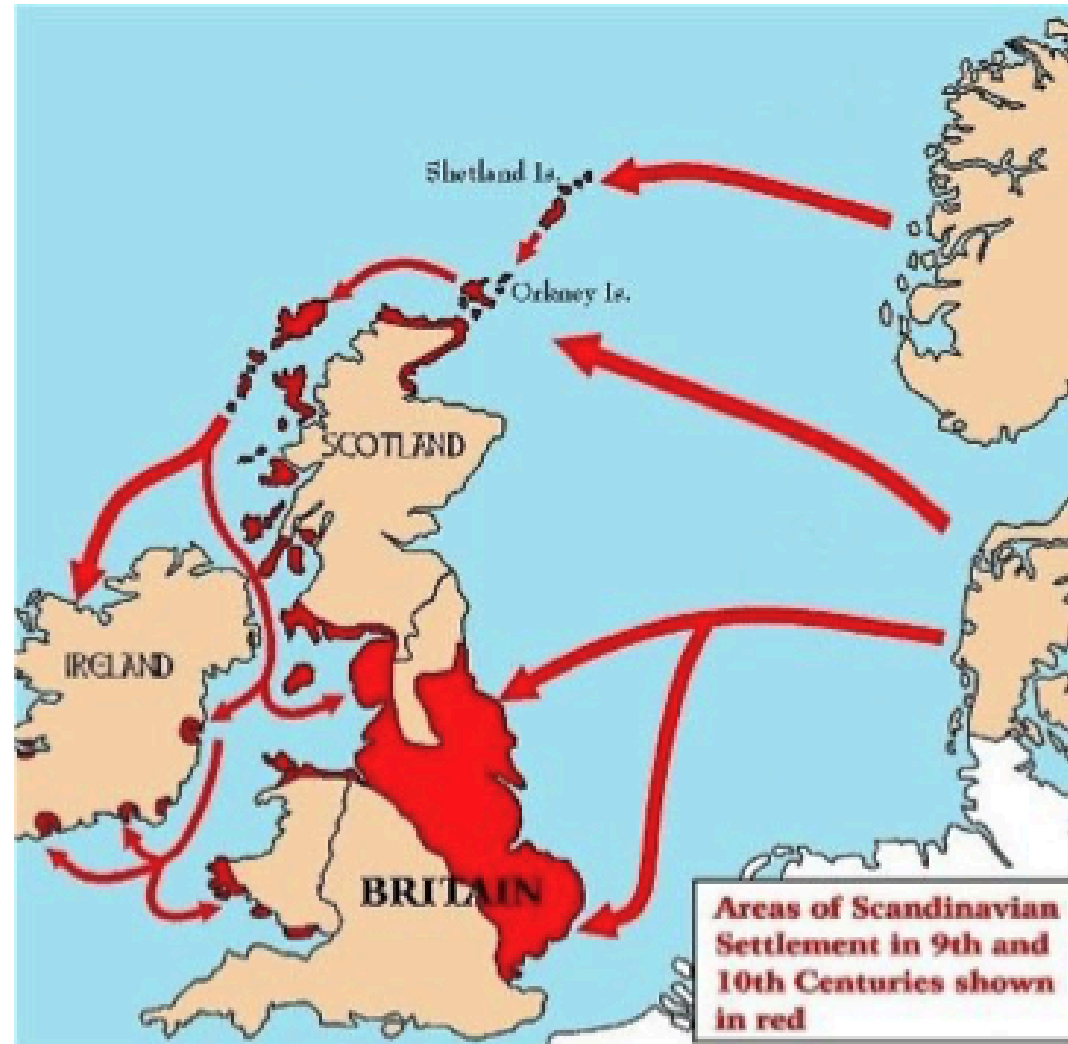
- **410** (traditional date according to Bede's *Historia Ecclesiastica Gentis Anglorum*: 449): Angles, Saxons and Jutes (and some Frisians), speaking varieties of West Germanic languages, conquer the main British Isle → **Germanic Conquest**
- **c. 700**: earliest written documents in Old English
- **from 6th century**: Christianization
 - Irish missionaries (c. 563 St. Columba to Iona)
 - missionaries from Rome (c. 597; St. Augustine to Canterbury)
- **from 8th century onwards**: Viking raids and Danish settlement
 - 793: sacking of Monastery of Lindisfarne
- **878**: establishment of the 'Danelaw'

Germanic conquest



Germanic tribes settling in Britain

Viking raids and the Danelaw



Viking raids and the Danelaw

Linguistic characteristics

- **Word order:** Relatively free.
- **Vocabulary:** Germanic with some Latin (e.g., *wine, cheese, street*) and Scandinavian (e.g. *take, die, sky*) loanwords.
- **Morphology:** An inflecting/synthetic language; nouns and adjectives inflect for 4 cases, 2 numbers, and 3 grammatical genders.

Middle English (ca. 1100–1500)

External history

- **1066**: Norman Conquest (William the Conqueror; Battle of Hastings)
- for more than three centuries, England was trilingual ('Triglossia'): (Anglo-)French and Latin as 'high variety' and English as 'low variety'
- **from mid-14th century**: English slowly reestablished in various domains (1349 English as language of education, 1362 opening of Parliament, literary language) → English re-introduced as high variety

High varieties

1. **Latin**: church, learning, documents
2. **French**: upper classes, feudal aristocracy

Low variety

3. **English**: peasants, lower clergy, most people in cities

Middle English linguistic characteristics

- **synthetic** → **analytic shift**: breakdown of inflection due to weakening of final syllables ('Entsilbenabschwächung': /a/, /u/, /o/ > /ə/ > Ø)
- **loss of grammatical gender** (c. 1200): article *the* adopts natural gender
- **increasingly fixed word order** (less flexibility)
- **dialect age**: no generally accepted standard
- **mass borrowing**: war/military, administration/law, religion/church, fashion, social life → mixed Germanic/Romance vocabulary
- huge number of **borrowings** in the field of war/military, administration/law, religion/church, fashion, social life etc. (+ influence on word formation and stress patterns) → end of Middle English: mixed Germanic/Romance vocabulary

Early Modern English (ca. 1500–1800)

External history

- **1476**: William Caxton introduces printing press to England
- **1492**: discovery of America
- **Renaissance and Humanism**: rediscovery of classical authors and literature (e.g. translations of classical literature)
- **1534**: Reformation
- **1611**: King James Bible (first official English translation of the Bible for the English church)
- growing literacy → literacy spread down the social ranks, and from the male to the female sex (→ new reading public → translations needed)

Key linguistic developments

- **Great Vowel Shift** (c. 1400/1500): Raising and diphthongisation of long vowels, increasing the discrepancy between spelling and pronunciation.
- **Inflectional system**: The weakening and loss of inflections continues.
- **Word order**: Becomes more fixed (SVO).
- **Standardisation**: Development of the London dialect into a new standard.
- **Orthography**: Emergence of a standardised spelling system.
- **Learned vocabulary**: Influx of loanwords from Latin and Greek ('hard words').

Late Modern English (ca. 1800–1945)

External history

- **from 1700s:** British Imperialism → expansion of English all over the world (Australia, India etc.)
- **1700s/1800s:** normativism and prescriptivism (1755: Samuel Johnson *A Dictionary of the English Language* → first comprehensive dictionary of the English language)
- **1900s:** scientific and industrial revolutions → development of technical registers

Linguistic characteristics

- **do-periphrasis**: Becomes obligatory in interrogatives and sentential negation (from 1700).
- **Grammaticalisation**: Beginning of the progressive aspect and present perfect (from 1800).
- **Pronunciation**: Standard British English (RP) becomes non-rhotic.
- **American English**: An emergent standard develops.
- **Global borrowing**: Vocabulary expands with words from languages around the world, leading to **vocabulary expansion and global influence**.

Present-Day English (since ca. 1945)

External history

- **New media:** The rise of telephone, TV, internet etc. accelerates change.
- **American English:** Increasing importance and influence after WWI and WWII.
- **Global English:** Established as a world language and a lingua franca.
- **Postcolonial Englishes:** Increasing importance (e.g., Indian English), contributing to a truly **global English** shaped by **technological change**.

Present-Day English lexicon

A unique mixture

“Der heutige englische Wortschatz ist eine einzigartige Mischung von germanischen und romanischen Elementen; in Bezug auf das Vokabular stellt also das Englische einen Sonderfall unter den europäischen Sprachen dar.” (Leisi 2008: 41)

Most frequent words in English

Analysis based on COCA:

Frequency			
rank	word/lemma	PoS	frequency
1	the	a	22038615
2	be	v	12545825
3	and	c	10741073
4	of	i	10343885
5	a	a	10144200
6	in	i	6996437
7	to	t	6332195
8	have	v	4303955
9	to	i	3856916
10	it	p	3872477

Top frequent words showing mixed origins

Languages of origin in high-frequency words

Scandinavian (Old Norse):

- *they, them, their, both, same, though*
- *to get, to take, to give, to call, to die, to seem, to want*

French:

- *people, very, country, part, place, point, change, large, sure, different*

French/Latin:

- *just, to use, number, state, question, form*

Germanic core vocabulary

Elements surviving from Old English form the basic vocabulary:

- **Pronouns, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs**
- **Fundamental concepts:**
 - OE *mann* → *man*
 - OE *wīf* → *wife*
 - OE *cīld* → *child*
 - OE *hūs* → *house*
 - OE *drincan* → *drink*
 - OE *libban* → *live*

Latin influence

Continental borrowings

- *street, wine, kitchen, mile, butter, cheese*

After settlement (post-450)

- *port, mount, -chester*

Christianisation

- *martyr, clerk, creed, nun, verse*

Renaissance and later

- *humanist, abdomen, skeleton*

Old Norse influence

Viking raids and the Danelaw

- Genetic resemblance between Old Norse and Old English
- Strong influence on **basic vocabulary**

Examples

- **Function words:** *they, them, their, though*
- **Verbs:** *to call, to die, to take, to raise*
- **Nouns:** *law, husband, egg, birth*
- **Adjectives:** *awkward, ill, weak*

Consequence: English drifts apart from West Germanic languages

French superstrate influence

Superstrate: socially/politically superior language influences inferior position

- **Government/Administration:** *authority, chancellor, council, court, crown, duke, empire, government, liberty, minister, noble, palace, parliament, prince, reign, royal, sovereign, treaty*
- **Law:** *accuse, advocate, assault, attorney, blame, crime, evidence, fraud, jail, judge, justice, pardon, plaintiff, prison, punishment, verdict*
- **Religion/Church:** *abbey, baptism, cathedral, charity, clergy, confess, divine, faith, immortality, mercy, religion, saint, sermon, temptation, virgin, virtue*
- **Military/Warfare:** *ambush, army, battle, captain, combat, defend, enemy, guard, navy, peace, soldier, spy*
- **Food:** *appetite, bacon, beef, cream, dinner, feast, fruit, herb, lemon, lettuce, mustard, mutton, olive, pork, salad, salmon, spice, veal*
- **Fashion:** *diamond, dress, fashion, fur, garment, gown, jewel, lace, robe, satin, wardrobe*

Loans from other languages

- **Portuguese/Spanish:** *marmalade, banana, cannibal, creole, mosquito, mulatto, tobacco*
- **Italian:** *alarm, million, balcony, opera, piazza, sonnet, stanza*
- **Greek:** *bible, character, climate, fantasy, horizon, tragedy*
- **Arabian:** *admiral, elixir, hazard, mosque, alcohol, alchemy*
- **Persian:** *azure, chess*

Global loan words

Table 3.1 Loan words from around the world

<i>Word</i>	<i>Source</i>	<i>Reaches English through</i>	<i>Date and comments</i>
algebra	Arabic	Latin	1551 (in the mathematical sense)
assassin	Arabic	French	1531 (in the sense 'murderer')
budgerigar	Yuwaalaraay		1847
bungalow	Hindustani		1676
caddy	Malay		1792
caravan	Persian	French	1596
commandeer	South African Dutch		1881
curry	Tamil		1598
haiku	Japanese		1899
igloo	Inuit		1856
kangaroo	Guugu Yimidhirr		1770
kiosk	Turkish or Persian	French	1625
kumquat	Cantonese		1699
marijuana	Nahuatl	Spanish	1874
moose	Eastern Abenaki		1614
potlatch	Nootka	Chinook Jargon	1844
pyjamas	Persian	Urdu	1801
raccoon	Algonquian		1608
safari	Swahili		1859
tank	Gujerati	Portuguese	1634
tea	Amoy Chinese	Malay, Dutch	1660
thug	Hindi		1810
toboggan	Micmac	French	1829
tulip	Turkish		1578
tycoon	Japanese		1857

Recent European loans and dialectal terms

Table 3.2 Some recent – and predominantly European – loan words

<i>Word</i>	<i>Source</i>	<i>Date</i>
Blitzkrieg	German	1939
bustier	French	1978
fado	Portuguese	1902
geisha	Japanese	1891
Gestalt	German	1992
glasnost	Russian	1981
hygge	Danish	1960
lingerie	French	1835
nacho	Spanish	1948
nosh	Yiddish	1873
ombudsman	Swedish	1872
rodeo	Spanish	1811
spaghetti	Italian	1845
tsunami	Japanese	1897

Recent borrowings from European languages

Table 3.3 Some dialectal terms in standard English

<i>Word</i>	<i>Dialectal source</i>	<i>Meaning</i>	<i>Date</i>
blackmail	Scottish		1530
craic	Irish or Ulster Scots		1972
emmet	Cornish	'tourist'	1975
flummox	Western England		1837
grockle	South-west England	'tourist'	1964
guffaw	Scots		1721
kerfuffle	Scots	'dispute, disorder'	1946
moke	Hampshire, Devon	'donkey'	1839
Scouse	Liverpool	'Liverpudlian'	1960
up the duff	Australian	'pregnant'	1941

Dialectal words entering standard English

Types of lexical change

Consequences of borrowing

Consociation vs Dissociation

Consociation: German

- *Mund – mündlich*
- *Heiliger – heilig*
- *Fuß – Fußgänger*
- *Wort – wörtlich*
- *Buch – Buchstabe – Bücherei*

Dissociation: English

- *mouth – oral*
- *saint – holy*
- *foot – pedestrian*
- *word – verbal*
- *book – letter – library*

Partial synonymy

Register differences

- *to ask* (c. 885) — neutral
- *to question* (c. 1470) — formal
- *to interrogate* (c. 1483) — official/legal

Connotational differences

- **solitude** vs *loneliness*
- **freedom** vs *liberty*

Result: Greater linguistic choice through partial synonyms

“Hard words”

Often etymologically unrelated → difficult to learn:

Examples of confusion (malapropisms)

- *illiterate* vs *illegitimate*
- *missile* vs *missive*
- *epitaph* vs *epithet*

Change in usage frequency

Lexical innovation

The interplay of cultural and linguistic innovation

- Society changes → new practices and products emerge
- Language changes first on the **lexical level** through **neologisms**

Lexical innovation

The interplay of cultural and linguistic innovation

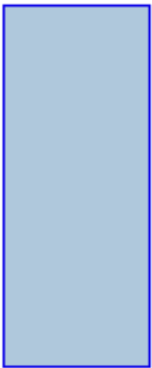
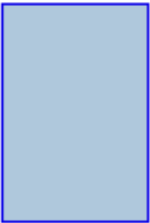
- Society changes → new practices and products emerge
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Examples:

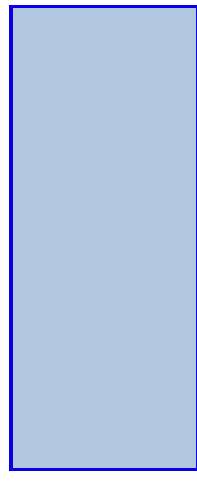
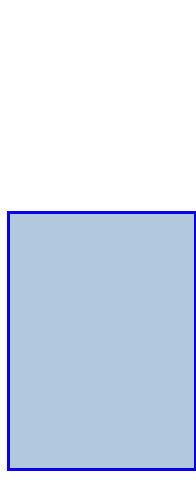
- **Formal neologisms:** *smartphone, iPhone, Covid*
- **Semantic neologisms:** *hotspot, Querdenker, social distancing, spreader*

Lexical attrition

Word loss through decreased frequency:

1990-94	1995-99	2000-04	2005-09	2010-14	2015-19
7050	6507	4352	3221	2346	1920
121.1	125.2	124.6	123.1	123.3	122.8
58.21	51.97	34.92	26.18	19.02	15.64
					

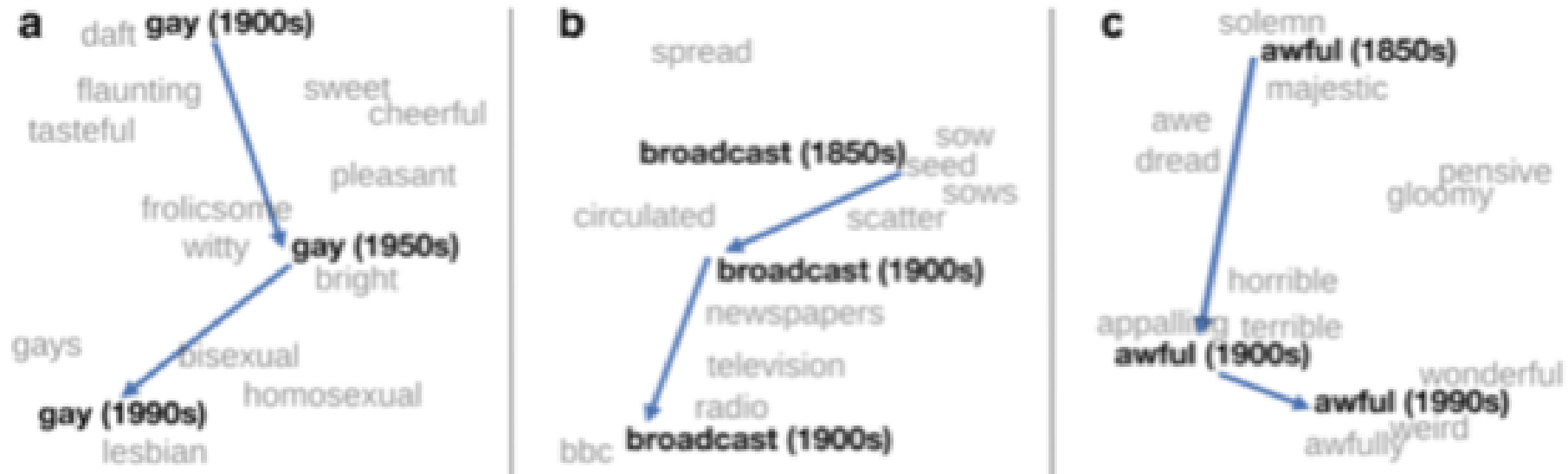
Frequency decline of *telephone* in COCA

	1960	1970	1980	1990	2000	2010
	0	0	51	59	34	15
	29.1	28.8	29.9	33.1	34.8	35.5
	0.00	0.00	1.71	1.78	0.98	0.42
						

Frequency decline of *Walkman* in COHA

Meaning change

Semantic change over time:

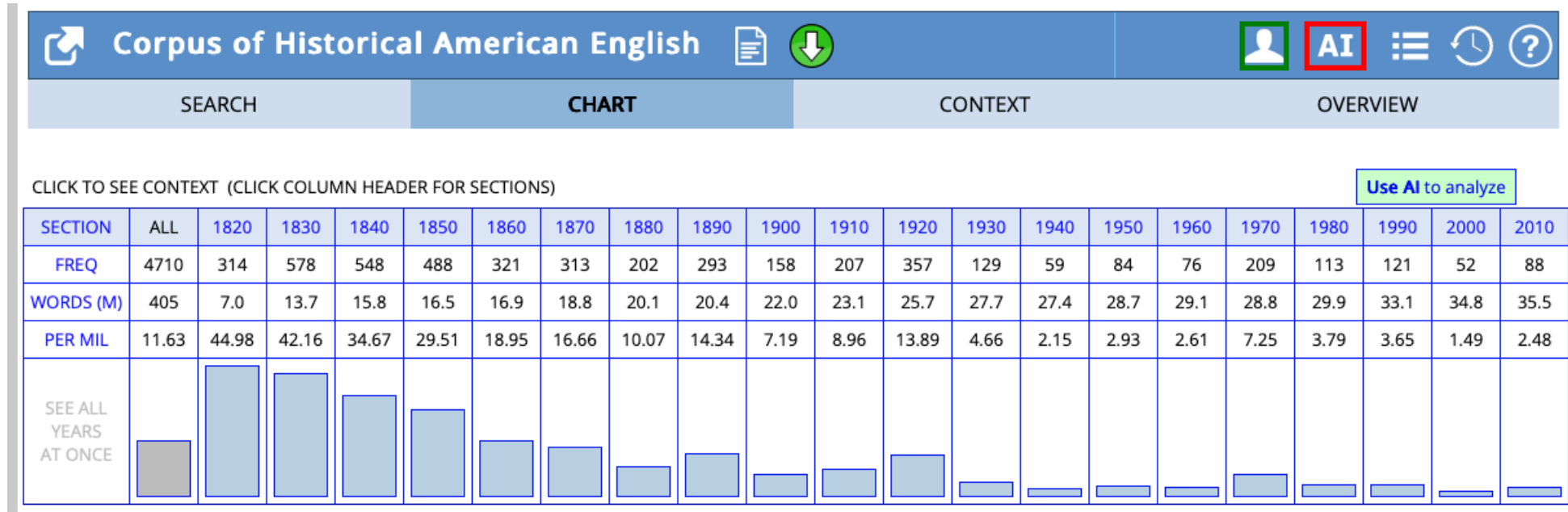


Types and directions of meaning change

Common patterns: narrowing, broadening, amelioration, pejoration

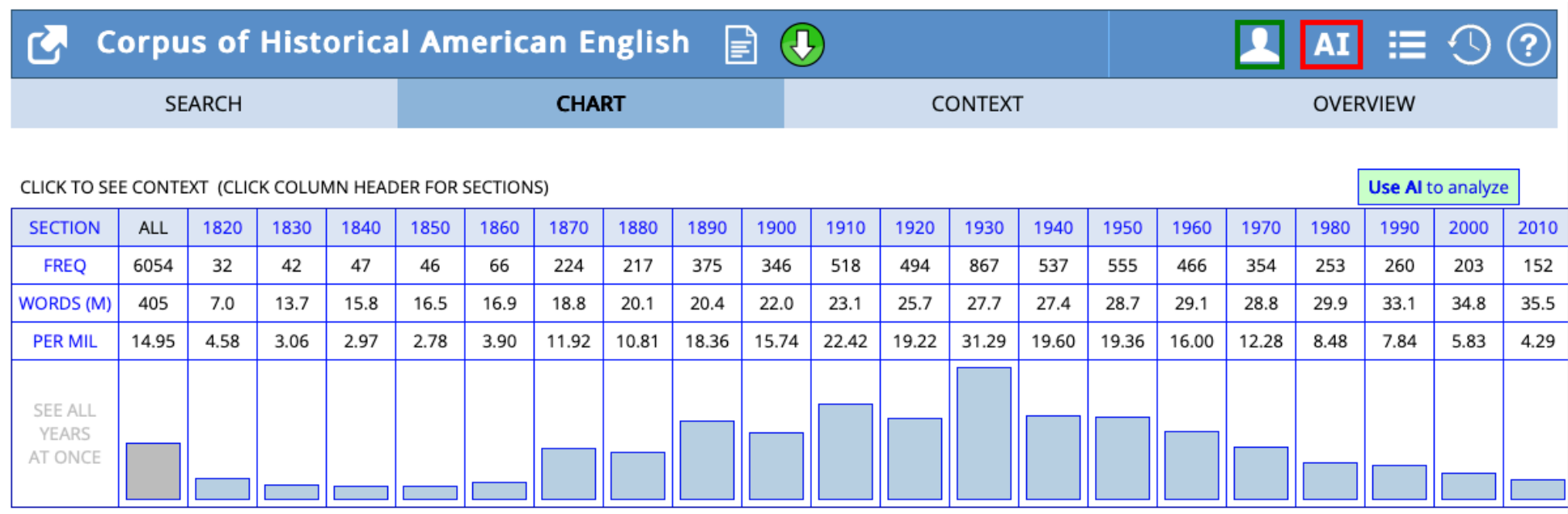
Examples of lexical changes

whilst



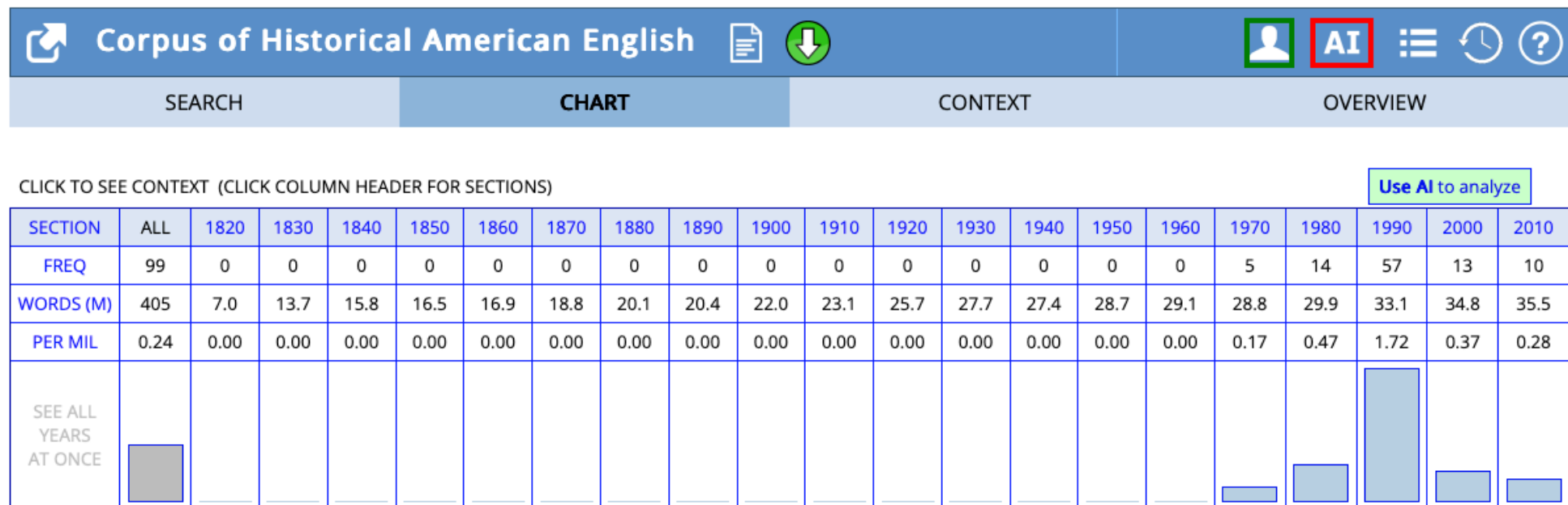
Frequency decline of *whilst* in the COHA.

awfully



Frequency of *awfully* in the COHA.

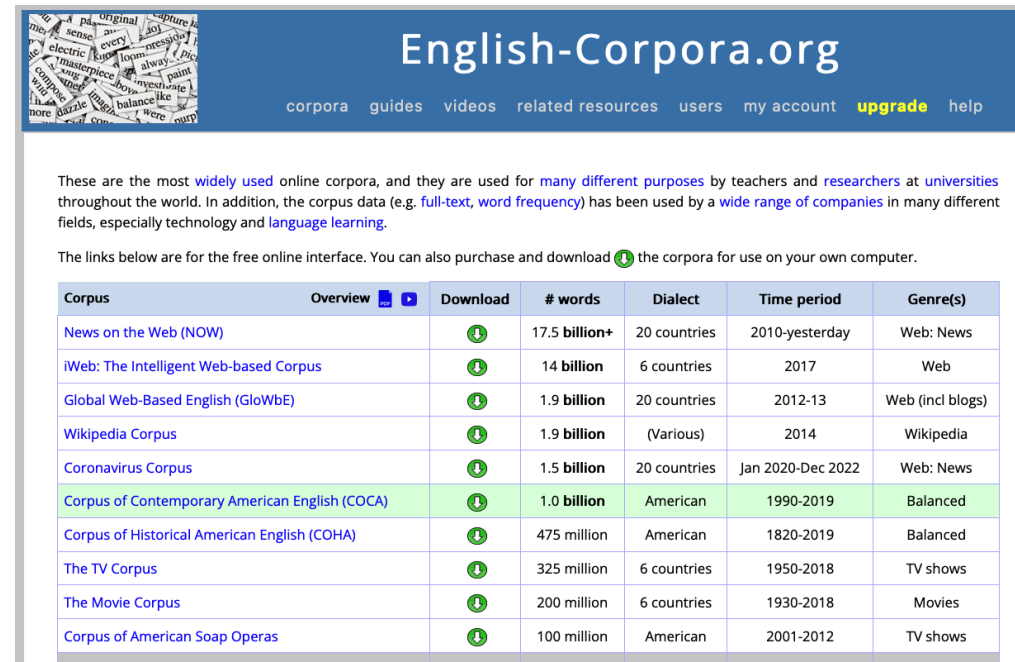
chairperson



Frequency of *chairperson* in the COHA.

How to use **english-** **corpora.org**

Overview of corpora



The screenshot shows the English-Corpora.org website. The header has the site name and navigation links: corpora, guides, videos, related resources, users, my account, upgrade, and help. A paragraph explains that these are widely used online corpora for various purposes. Below this is a table listing several corpora with their word counts, dialects, time periods, and genres.

Corpus	Overview	Download	# words	Dialect	Time period	Genre(s)
News on the Web (NOW)			17.5 billion+	20 countries	2010-yesterday	Web: News
iWeb: The Intelligent Web-based Corpus			14 billion	6 countries	2017	Web
Global Web-Based English (GloWbE)			1.9 billion	20 countries	2012-13	Web (incl blogs)
Wikipedia Corpus			1.9 billion	(Various)	2014	Wikipedia
Coronavirus Corpus			1.5 billion	20 countries	Jan 2020-Dec 2022	Web: News
Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA)			1.0 billion	American	1990-2019	Balanced
Corpus of Historical American English (COHA)			475 million	American	1820-2019	Balanced
The TV Corpus			325 million	6 countries	1950-2018	TV shows
The Movie Corpus			200 million	6 countries	1930-2018	Movies
Corpus of American Soap Operas			100 million	American	2001-2012	TV shows

Available corpora on english-corpora.org

- **COHA**: Corpus of Historical American English: 400+ million words, 1820–2010, decade-by-decade analysis ([Davies 2010](#))
- **COCA**: Corpus of Contemporary American English: 1+ billion words, 1990–present, text type categories ([Davies 2008](#))
- **NOW**: News on the Web: 20+ billion words, 2010–present, 20 countries ([Davies 2016](#))

Views

List view

List view for query `admin*` in COCA

Chart view

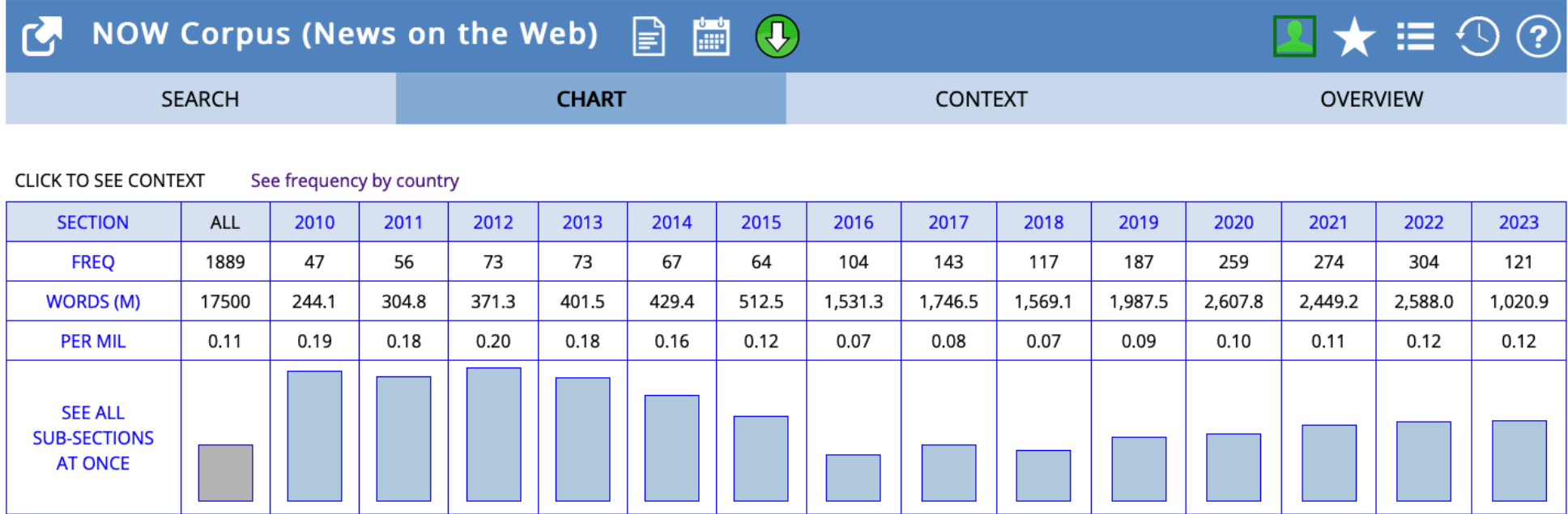


Chart view for query **decaf** in NOW corpus

Query syntax

Lexemes (all forms of a word)

<

Query **ADMIN** (all forms) in NOW corpus

Use capital letters to search for all forms: **WALK** finds *walk*, *walks*, *walked*, *walking*

Word classes

 **NOW Corpus (News on the Web)**   

SEARCHCHARTCONTEXTOVERVIEW

List **Chart** Collocates Compare KWIC

Search by date

☐ Sections ☐ Texts/Virtual sections

_pos

✓ noun.ALL

verb.ALL

adj.ALL

adv.ALL

neg.ALL

art.ALL

det.ALL

pron.ALL

poss.ALL

prep.ALL

conj.ALL

interj.ALL

punc.ALL

noun.ALL+

noun.SG

noun.PL

noun.COM



Use the dropdown list to the left (POS or _pos) to input tags for "parts of speech" (PoS, e.g. nouns or verbs) into your search string.

By default, it will add the PoS as a "full word", as in the searches [strong NOUN](#) or [ADJ eyes](#).

You can also have the PoS added as a "tag" on the end of a word, to limit the word to that PoS, as in the searches [strike_n](#) or [and FIND_v](#).

To make it insert PoS tags after words, click on [_pos](#). To change it back to PoS as a separate "word", click on [POS](#).

Query [run_nn](#) (noun) in NOW corpus

NOW Corpus (News on the Web)

SEARCH

CHART

CONTEXT

OVERVIEW

SECTION: 2010 (44,467)

FIND SAMPLE: [100](#) [200](#) [500](#) [1000](#)

PAGE: << < 1 / 445 > >>

CLICK FOR MORE CONTEXT

SAVE

TRANSLATE

ANALYZE

HELP

1	10-12-31 JM	Jamaica Observer			Q	but had resigned because he did not approve of the way the sport was being run . # He added that the new board had inherited a lot of deb
2	10-12-31 JM	Jamaica Observer			Q	the bedmate? When an MP's bedmate buys land where the new road will run , pads to consultant in the firm about to get a state contract, ca
3	10-12-31 IN	Rediff			Q	energy. # " And a dream of Ratan Tata is eventually cars will be run on water. My dream is also that, " he said, referring to
4	10-12-31 IN	Rediff			Q	water-powered cars! # Tata Group chairman Ratan Tata's dream is to see cars run on water and he has invested \$15 million in a start-up fir
5	10-12-31 IN	NDTV.com			Q	empty and undamaged bottles of foreign-made liquor with the labels intact and used them to run the illegal racket. # The trio from Kerala u
6	10-12-31 IN	NDTV.com			Q	" Both sides are very keen that the next session (of Parliament) should run in order... I am very, very optimistic on how the events will unfol
7	10-12-31 IN	Deccan Herald			Q	temperature does not go up much, " Dr Charkoudian said, but if you run hard for an hour or so, you can have what seems like a fever
8	10-12-31 IN	Times of India			Q	Jumbo Multi Axle' buses. These buses will have additional seating capacity and will run at a faster speed. The buses will be introduced on ro
9	10-12-31 IN	Times of India			Q	of cost to the MSRTC for a period of one month. These will be run on the Swargate-Dadar route. Trips will leave daily at 7.30 am and 4 pm
10	10-12-31 IN	Moneylife Personal Finance Magazine			Q	Katara couldn't get away because of alert citizen pressure. The drunken hit and run at Mumbai and Delhi are still hanging fire. Nothing seem

Query **run_vv** (verb) in NOW corpus

Common tags: **_nn** (noun), **_vv** (verb), **_jj** (adjective), **_rb** (adverb)

Wildcards

- ***** matches any characters: **admin*** → *admin, administration, administrator*
- **?** matches single character: **wom?n** → *woman, women*

Useful features

- **Sections:** Filter by text type (fiction, academic, spoken, etc.)
- **Chart:** Visualize frequency over time or across categories
- **KWIC:** View concordance lines (keyword in context)
- **Collocates:** Find words that frequently co-occur

Practice: language change in
progress

Overview

Investigate language change in progress using the COHA.

Phenomena

1. *whom* vs *who*
2. *try to* vs *try and*
3. *have gotten* vs *have got*

Task

Collect your findings in this PowerPoint presentation:

https://1drv.ms/p/c/9a2ec97d593520f9/IQDU1gjOhJMBSqmABzQtcktWAZyTrvf_0zYOHERnCkdNSSk.

1. Investigate the frequency over time in the COHA.
2. Compare frequency across text types in the COCA.
3. Compare frequency across countries in the NOW corpus.
4. Read concordance lines: do the forms differ with regards to their usage in different contexts?

Group findings

1. What are your results?
2. How can we interpret them linguistically?
3. What might explain these changes?

Discussion

What general trends might explain these changes?

References

- Davies, Mark. 2008. "The Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA): 560 Million Words, 1990-Present." 2008. <https://www.english-corpora.org/coca/>.
- . 2010. "The Corpus of Historical American English (COHA): 400 Million Words, 1810-2009." 2010. <https://www.english-corpora.org/coha/>.
- . 2016. "Corpus of News on the Web (NOW) - 3+ Billion Words from 20 Countries, Updated Every Day." 2016. <https://www.english-corpora.org/now/>.